specialising in corporate wrongdoing, provides a caustic if glib account of America's misdeeds. He cites the Bush administration's foreign policy, the rendition (kidnapping) and torture of terrorist suspects, past incidents of warrantless wiretapping, and much more besides. These are real problems and should indeed provoke soul-searching among those who wish the West to occupy the moral high ground, and for democracies to maintain their political and economic pre-eminence. But they are no excuse for nihilism.

As the journalist Brendan O'Neill points out:[56]

> Conspiracy theorising and the cult of the whistle-blower have the same origins: a crisis of democracy, the collapse of public engagement, and a dearth of faith in politicians and even in politics itself. The more that some people feel alienated from politics, cut off from the old to-and-fro of political debate, the more they can feel tempted to embrace hare-brained stories about tiny cliques of rich folk or lizards or Jews running everything behind our backs. Conspiracy theories feed off the carcass of democratic engagement. And so it is with whistle-blowing, too: the more that radicals lose faith in both the political system, which they view as totally corrupt, and the little people, who are 'wilfully ignorant', the more they come to believe that only brave, truth-wielding individuals can save the world from enslavement by a dastardly elite.

The Snowdenistas' extremism and hyperbole reflect a mind-set which the blogger Catherine A Fitzpatrick has outlined well in her essay 'When Thinking Styles Collide'.[57] She was actually writing about the geek world's attitude to anti-piracy legislation, but the points she makes also highlight the weakness of other self-described crusaders for digital freedom, who scorn the law-making process, and judicial and parliamentary oversight, as out-of-date or irrelevant in the digital age. Geeks, she says, do not 'get' governance.